

The voyage begins at dawn
as the small boat departs
from the quiet northern shore.
The river runs smooth and wide,
carrying the traveler onward
through valleys green and still.
By evening the current quickens
toward the distant grey sea.

In the capital that same week
the council met in secret
to debate the coming war.
Messengers rode through the night
bearing sealed and urgent letters
to every allied province.
No one yet knew the outcome
of those long and bitter talks.